

pick of the week



Threads of summer

A love letter to handwoven cotton, Raw Mango's Midsummer 2026 SOOTI collection finds its muse in architecture, nostalgia and the poetry of everyday dressing. Shot at Delhi's iconic Gujral House, the campaign captures the quiet, cinematic mood of 1970s and '80s independent Indian films. Expect saris in new weaves, playful colour palettes and drapes designed for everyday wear. The collection is now available online and at Raw Mango stores.



Wild reptile stories

What can crocodiles, snakes and turtles teach us about surviving the odds? Quite a lot. Join zoo biologist Vani Sri Damodaran of the Madras Crocodile Bank Trust as she unpacks 320 million years of reptile evolution, exploring how these ancient creatures adapted, endured and continue to shape our understanding of intelligence, resilience and the natural world. On July 5, from 4pm onwards at Bhola and Blonde, KNK Road. Register at kynhood.com



Shop, sip, savour

Travel across India without leaving Chennai. Karigar Bazaar makes its city debut with a celebration of handmade traditions. Browse crafts by over 200 artisans, catch live folk performances from Rajasthan and Madhya Pradesh, watch craft demonstrations, and feast on regional favourites — from Purani Delhi chaat to Gujarati fare. The bazaar runs from July 10 to 19, 11am 8pm, at Mantra Gardens, Nandanam Extension. Entry ₹50.



The craft edit

Sparo Living, a Tamil Nadu-based lifestyle brand with a women-led workforce, is introducing a collection of handcrafted home and lifestyle products that bring together contemporary design

and natural materials. Made from banana fibre, seagrass and jute, its collection includes handbags, baskets, tableware and storage solutions. Prices start at ₹300 onwards. Buy online on sparoliving.com



THE NAKED TRUTH

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Finding love after a divorce is rarely just about downloading a dating app and hoping the algorithm has finally learned your type. For single parents, romance comes with a third wheel: their children.

A recent survey by Rebound, touted as India's first matchmaking and matrimony platform for divorced, separated and widowed singles, found that 47% of single parents say their children shape their romantic decisions, even when they are not actively involved in the matchmaking process. The survey, conducted among 8,576 divorced, separated and widowed single parents, also found that more than half of single mothers (51%) and nearly half of single fathers (48%) had walked away from a promising relationship because they feared it would disrupt the stability they had painstakingly built for their children.

It is a peculiar kind of emotional arithmetic where every flutter of possibility must first pass through an internal risk assessment that asks: Will this make my child feel less secure?

For a 54-year-old father from Delhi, whose two children are now in their 20s, that calculation

Swipe right, parent first

Single parents reveal how guilt, responsibility and their children's emotional wellbeing shape the search for love after divorce

has become easier with time. His divorce was amicable, his children are adults building lives of their own, and his work keeps him travelling across cities anyway.

"In your 50s, you're looking for peace," he says. What strikes him, though, is not his own experience but how differently the world treats women navigating the same chapter.

"As a man, people almost congratulate you for getting back out there," he says. "There's this assumption that remarriage is healthy, almost expected."

His children have never objected to him dating, nor does he feel compelled to seek

their approval. "I've seen women my age treated very differently. They're expected to devote themselves



children didn't approve of," she says. "I've learned that children's instincts are often better than ours."

According to Mumbai-based psychotherapist Samay Ajmera, that is a pattern he encounters often in his practice. Single parents, he says, are not necessarily more fearful of love after divorce; they carry a different set of responsibilities into it.

"I've had clients in their early 30s who have no interest in dating because they're still carrying the hurt, mistrust or exhaustion from the marriage," he says. "Then I've met people in their 40s who are genuinely excited to meet someone because they've had the time to process what happened."

One question comes up repeatedly in therapy, he tells me: I don't know if I'm scared of dating or scared of making another mistake. "Those are two very different fears. The first is about intimacy while the second is about responsibility."

That responsibility is particularly acute for single mothers, many of whom are simultaneously raising children, working full-time and carrying the invisible labour that rarely makes it onto dating profiles.

Dating is also infinitely easier if grandparents can babysit, a co-parent is cooperative, or family can step in for a few hours. Without that support, romance can become a logistical impossibility.

Perhaps the biggest shift after parenthood is that love is no longer evaluated on chemistry alone. "They are asking whether this person adds to the sense of stability they've fought hard to create for their child," says Samay.

The takeaway is simple: falling in love may still be possible, but it now has to fit around school pickups, emotional safety and the hope that this time, nobody, least of all the children, gets hurt.

A fortnightly guide to love in the age of bare minimum



(Clockwise from left) Costume designers Sophie De Rakoff and Sara Byblow during the design process; and stills from Elle. PRIME VIDEO AND SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



moment of the film stayed with her. "The scene where she runs into Warner at Harvard wearing a blue green cardigan that looks like a smoking jacket, and a hot pink shirt... it was just so creative," she says, of Elle's outfit in the iconic, "Like it's hard?" scene. The red Bottega bag Elle carries in this scene finds its way back into the prequel; her mother Eva is seen with the bag.

Working on the spinoff meant delving into the script and stepping into the mind of Elle Woods, a Y2K icon who Sara says is someone who makes very conscious choices not just for herself and her actions, but her wardrobe as well.

When Elle lands in Seattle in a cute, tennis-inspired baby pink satin dress on the first day of high school, she finds herself in a sea of grey, grungy plaids and hoodies. This very visceral difference is

something they actively worked on achieving, Sara explains, to spotlight Elle being a fish out of water. "We did a look test with her in that pink satin dress, against the dull lockers and grey plaids to get it right. The pink had to be the perfect shade; to show how vulnerable and lost she feels in a new place," she recalls. Elle begins with



Elle's sweet 16 birthday party, where she steps out in a hot pink mini dress with a large, shiny bow. This outfit was designed by Sara, with Sophie De Rakoff, who worked on the costumes for the Legally Blonde films.

"I was thankful to have the opportunity to spend time with her, ask her about working with Reese on the films, and sketch the sweet 16 dress. It felt like she was passing the design torch to me, much like Reese is to Lexi for Elle, and it was nice to have this crossover time for me to become a lot more confident with my role here," she says.

Sara says they were very certain of not wanting the film to look like a documentary of 1995. Given that Elle, both in the films and the shows is never defined by one single designer or trend, sourcing for the film happened from everywhere; designer clothes, archival pieces, thrift and vintage stores and so on. "The fact that Elle Woods is such a singular character is why her sense of style is still celebrated nearly 25 years on. We wanted to carry forward this legacy," she explains.

As for all there is to love about pink, Sara says it has become this vision of female empowerment for her, after working on the show.

"I have absolutely fallen more in love with the colour now, I feel like it has almost turned into a neutral colour for me," she says, adding with a laugh, "I did not know how many pinks there are in the world."

Elle is streaming on Prime Video

Pretty in pink

Costume designer Sara Byblow talks about dressing young Elle Woods, finding empowerment in pink, and recreating the fashion legacy of the Legally Blonde universe for Prime Video's Elle

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Costume designer Sara Byblow is in pink. I am too, and we share a chuckle on our video call when I point this out. The colour feels appropriate, given that we are sitting down to discuss our favourite 'Gemini vegetarian', Elle Woods.

The iconic heroine of the 2001 film Legally Blonde is starting a new chapter with Elle, a Prime Video original series that serves as a prequel. The show follows a younger Elle Woods (played by Lexi Minnetree) as she leaves glitzy Los Angeles behind for grungy Seattle. Set six years before the hit film that starred Reese Witherspoon, the show

chronicles Elle's high school years.

Much like the movies, pink (many, many shades of it) here is a main character, and Sara worked on designing a wardrobe for Lexi, as she struggles to fit into her new high school, the ensemble supporting cast which includes her very fashionable parents, a large contingent of high schoolers outfitted in blacks, greys and charcoal, and of course, her chic Chihuahua, little Bruiser, who gets his own Lacoste tennis outfit and Burberry raincoat.

She recalls watching Legally Blonde years ago, and how every

Mamdani approved

The New York City mayor dined with his wife Rama Duwaji and his parents at Chef Regi Mathew's Chatti, in Manhattan



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Chatti, Chennai-based Chef Regi Mathew's restaurant in New York City, welcomed a special family for dinner on Sunday, treating them to a slice of Kerala's culinary heritage in the Garment District.

Zohran Mamdani, mayor of New York City, his wife, illustrator Rama Duwaji, and his parents, filmmaker Mira Nair, and Ugandan professor and political commentator, Mahmood Mamdani, enjoyed a curated meal at the restaurant.

Mira Nair in a note thanked Chef Regi and the team for transporting her family to Kerala, on the streets of New York.

"It was a pleasure to welcome Mayor Zohran Mamdani, his wife Rama, and his parents, Meera Nair and Professor Mamdani, to

Chatti in New York. Sharing a meal is at the heart of what we do and it was lovely to host the family over a table of Kerala-inspired dishes," says Chef Regi Mathew, founder-partner, Chatti, of their visit. "At Chatti, we hope every meal creates a sense of connection through food, and conversation and we are delighted they chose to spend part of their time with us and thank them for their visit."

Back in Chennai, chef Regi is best known for his restaurant, Kappa Chakka Kandhari (with a branch in Bengaluru as well), for its traditional Kerala fare and seafood specialties such as deep fried mussels, clams roasted with coconut and spices, and kodampuli fish.

Named after the ubiquitous clay pot, a traditional fixture across homes and toddy shops in Kerala, Chatti, which opened in 2025, specialises in food from kallu or toddy shops where groups of men gather to drink freshly harvested toddy alongside local delicacies, also called 'touchings'.

(Above) Chatti, New York; and (right) Zohran Mamdani. ALEX STANILOFF AND GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK





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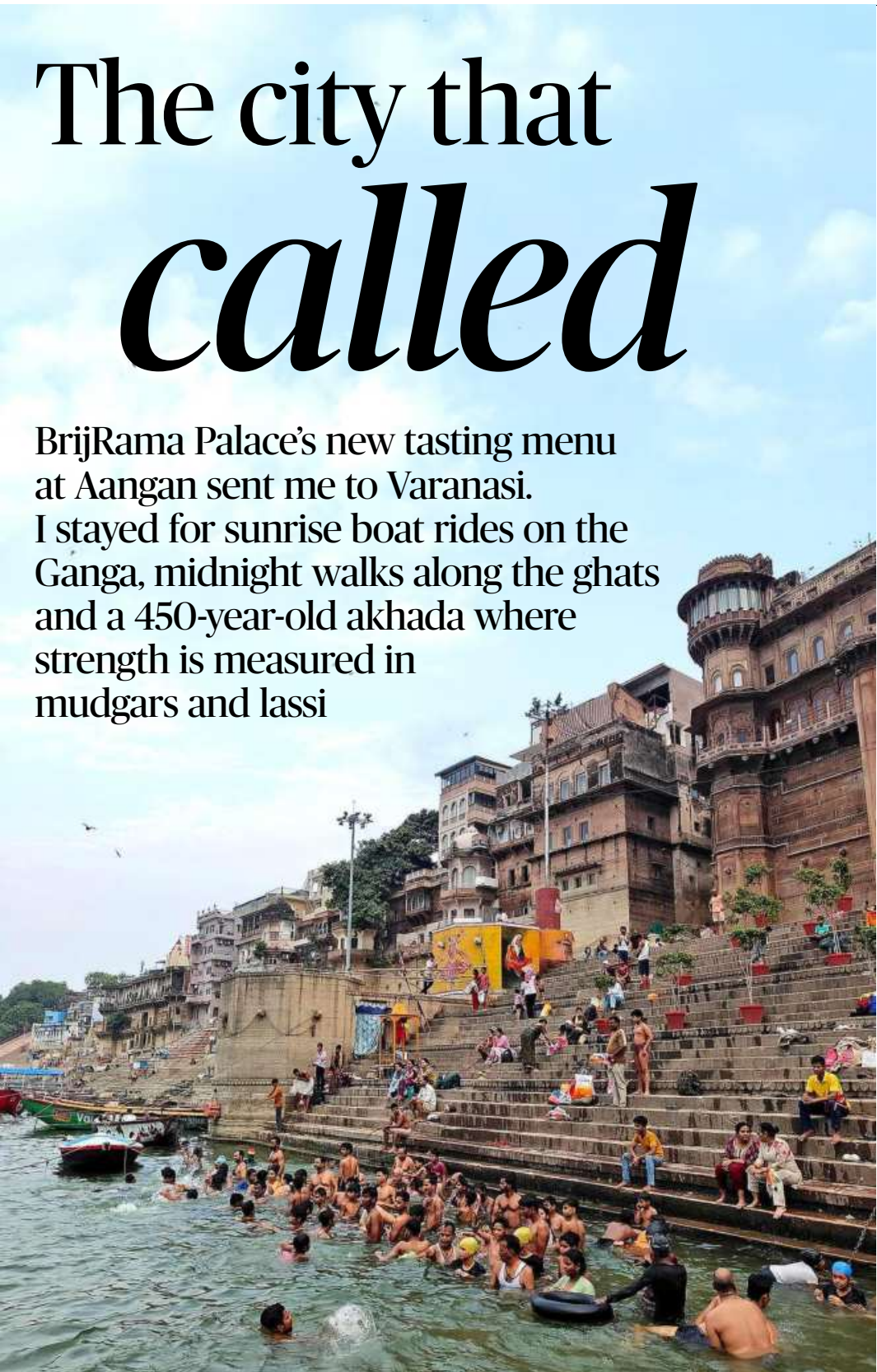
SMART
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(Clockwise from below) 4689 Coffee Roasters; BrijRama Palace at Darbhanga Ghat; the Bada Aangan courtyard; the Benarasi thali; the Aangan menu; and Gyanshankul Singh. SHONALI MUTHALALY AND SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



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We plunge into *tamatar chaat* weather in Varanasi. The days are warm and sticky, like the city's favourite snack: a soupy bowl of tomatoes and potatoes simmered in ghee, then finished with a flourish of butter and crisp *namkeen*. I recoil at my first steamy spoonful, wedged between samosa-wielding strangers on a hard, sweaty bench at Kashi Chaat Bandar. The waiters suggest *dahi bhalla* instead, with lashings of cool yoghurt, and find me a table near their sputtering air-conditioner so I can wallow in its asthmatic puffs of cool air. I have been drawn to Varanasi by promises of "fortified heritage radish bricks". BrijRama Palace, set at Darbhanga Ghat, with mesmerising views of the Ganga has just launched a 10-course vegetarian tasting menu. Served at its fine dining restaurant Aangan, this is the 214-year-old fort-turned-palace-turned-hotel's signal that it can balance contemporary luxury with the responsibilities that come with being a historic property on an iconic ghat set in one of the oldest living cities in the world. The menu, I am promised, also includes a 'celestial Guardian amuse-bouche' and 'Rasmalai tres leches cake'. *Tamatar chaat* and 45°C weather notwithstanding, I hop on a plane. An evening by the Ganga It is my first visit to the city, also referred to as Benares or Kashi, depending on whom



you are talking to. On our first evening, we weave through crowded *gullies* where the scent of *kachoris*, fresh garlands, and damp earth mingle, making our way to the Alka hotel, which offers a spectacular view of the river at dusk. Over tall glasses of chilled *thandai*, creamy with soaked cashewnuts, we follow the rhythm of flaming lamps as the sun sets and Ganga *aarti* at Dashashwamedh Ghat begins. From Alka, we walk South along the river towards Assi Ghat, pausing to listen to knots of young locals who gather in the evenings to sing, play the guitar, and in one case, the flute. After an obligatory slice of cinnamon-scented apple pie with bronzed edges at Pizzeria Vaatika, which declares it is 'India's oldest pizzeria,' we end the night at Pahawan lassi. Served in a *matka*, it is made from milk sourced from the village of Chandauli, then topped with rose water and deeply caramelised *rabri*. Checking into history The next day, BrijRama Palace's boat picks us up from the recently built Namoo Ghat. Uniformed attendants pour cups of hot *tulsi* chai as we glide past the ghats, including Manikarnika, which shimmers in the morning sun lit by pyres that burn incessantly. The boat docks at scenic Darbhanga Ghat, weaving through devotees taking a sacred dip and swimming children shrieking with laughter as they cool off. I try to photograph BrijRama Palace's reception committee, led by a man with a magnificent moustache and oversized red umbrella fringed with gold tassels, but, every angle invariably includes freshly emerged bathers struggling into their trousers behind scanty *gamchas*. As if the umbrella is not theatrical enough, a conch heralds my arrival as I enter the hotel. Inside, over a Benares thali featuring local staples – including addictive *khatta meeta kaddu*, pumpkin laced with tamarind and jaggery; cumin-scented *dimona* with green peas; and *alu dum* stuffed with paneer – general manager Manish Singh gives us a quick history lesson. First built as a fort n 1812 by Shridhara Narayana Munshi, minister to the Nagpur estate, it was acquired in 1915 by Rameshwar Singh Bahadur, king of Darbhanga. In suitably regal fashion, he installed Asia's first elevator: a hand-pulled contraption to spare him the steep climb to what became his palace. Now a 32-room hotel, this is clearly a labour of love, prizing passion over economics. After Brijrama Hospitality acquired the then dilapidated building in 1994, it took 18 (no doubt expensive) years to restore. "This is a UNESCO-protected site. We needed to get sandstone from Mirzapur, and bring construction material, including 90 kilo pillars via boats and through those small *gullies* since cars have to stop about a



Plating a palace

Aangan's menu, designed to showcase the history of Varanasi pays tribute to the guardians of the hotel. It opens with fire, smoke and a savoury *achappam* biscuit that looks like jewellery, paired with an emerald flourish of peas and curry leaf. The promised radish bricks are served in a refreshing moat of chaas. While there are the inevitable dips that come with an ambitious, experimental menu it is at its best when confident flavours outshine clever technique. Don't miss the cauliflower croquettes with pickled carrots, unveiled in a puff of savoury smoke



kilometre away," Manish says. The interiors, combining sun-soaked sandstone with Makrana marble are assembled with magpie-like enthusiasm: vintage furniture sourced from royal estate sales, Tehkari mirror work, vibrant frescoes and at the centre of it all the Bada Aangan courtyard. Since this was originally a fort, rooms are of varied sizes, with their crown jewel being Varuna Burj, a restored cannon room, which makes up for its diminutive size with a 180-degree view of the Ganga. I wake up to the sound of a flute, which feels suitably cinematic, given the setting.

Beyond the palace walls BrijRama's greatest strength is encouraging guests to view Varanasi as a part of the palace experience, instead of just closeting them in luxury with a view. Even just stepping out, into Darbhanga Ghat, envelopes us in its rhythms.

As we walk, we meet Akiko who runs a pocket-sized Japanese café, 4689 Coffee Roasters, supervised by her sanguine pug, Kushi. We chat with students from Benares Hindu University at the ghats selling freshly painted watercolours to raise money for an exhibition. And at least two passing Aghoris greet me as "Lakshmi," much to my delight.

Then, at Tulsi Ghat, we spend a morning at the 450-year-old Swaminath Akhara, where certified strength coach, arm wrestler and self-confessed poet Gyanshankul Singh teaches us how to swing the challenging Hanuman *gada*. We struggle with the lighter *mudgars*, while he and his friends gracefully wield wooden and stone versions weighing up to 68 kilos.

Beside us wrestlers in rippling muscles and *langots* grapple in dark, silky soft mud, which Gyanshankul explains comes from the banks of the Ganga, and is then mixed with "buttermilk, turmeric, mustard oil, alum, sandalwood powder, camphor, lemon juice and Gangajal". The atmosphere is warm and supportive, especially when Gyanshankul encourages us to follow the workout with freshly fried *jalebis* and lassi, "to stay healthy".

Legend says you only visit Varanasi when it calls you. Drawn by an improbable blend of radish bricks, *gadas* and *tamatar chaat* weather, I'm glad I answered.

The writer was in Varanasi on invitation from BrijRama Palace.



CONTINUED FROM
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With two timelines, two fundamentally different people in love, and a conflict that pushes the couple to consider eloping before they get separated, the trailer of *Main Vaapas Aaunga* suffered from a sense of familiarity. Imtiaz's biggest hits, such as *Love Aaj Kal* and *Jab We Met*, had similar tropes. "When the trailer of *Main Vaapas Aaunga* was out, many felt it was another *Love Aaj Kal*. A bit of worry crept into my team," admits Imtiaz. "However, I was very sure that this was a different movie. This movie has two timelines, and a young man and his older self are pivotal to the plot. This was something we saw in *Love Aaj Kal*. To make sure that *Main Vaapas Aaunga* doesn't resemble that, I didn't cast the same actor in the young and old roles. If the young and old characters were written for

the same actor, we could have signed a big star. We didn't go in that direction. We wanted two authentic performers representing two timelines. I also knew that when we reveal more about the core concept – the Partition – they would wash away all the memories of *Love Aaj Kal*," explains the filmmaker. While an earnest Vedang Raina essayed the young Ishar, Naseeruddin Shah played the older version of the character. In what is easily one of the finest performances by an Indian actor this year, Shah fully embodies Ishar, suffering from dementia and burdened by the painful memories of the Partition. Imtiaz says Shah is an actor who

Stills from *Main Vaapas Aaunga*; and Imtiaz Ali. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



The stories we carry

defies methods. "It took four hours for him to be ready for scenes because of the prosthetic makeup. He had to lie down, and we had to wire him and put chest leads. So, every time we had to change the light or a shot, he had no option but to lie down on the bed. While the lightman climbed on top of him to change the settings, he would talk to himself. Sometimes, when I got close to him to explain a scene, I heard him mumble bogus words. That was his way of staying in the character of a person suffering from dementia and to keep the mood of the scene alive," describes Imtiaz. He further says, "He had a childlike interest in the movie. When it comes to acting, he



performs with the energy of a passionate young actor." *Main Vaapas Aaunga* is perhaps Imtiaz's second film after *Chamkila*

to deal with a social subject and to use a relationship as a tool to drive the theme. For someone celebrated for depicting the complex dynamics of relationships against gorgeous backdrops, Imtiaz seems to have evolved as a filmmaker trying to say something significant through the stories of his lead couples.

Longing and loss "That's a fair point," he agrees. "I haven't done it deliberately, though. I wanted to make a film on the dichotomy of Punjab. I felt the story of *Chamkila* was perfect for it. That's the reason you see the Punjab-ness of the plot in the forefront. Similarly, I wanted to say something about the Partition. What did we lose from it? What did we break? Why don't we mention it often? Then came a story to answer these questions."

Does that mean Imtiaz has turned into a political filmmaker? "Not really. But, you can't avoid the politics of a place," he points out. "I am also wary of using the word politics, because today, politics means party politics. The dynamics of the relationships come first in my movies. Sometimes, politics is adopted as a convenience for those relationships to prosper. For instance, in *Main Vaapas Aaunga*, the couple doesn't want the Partition to happen because they want to be together." *Main Vaapas Aaunga* has gone on to overpower popular franchise movies (*Cocktail 2* and *Welcome To The Jungle*) to stage a remarkable victory.

Imtiaz confesses that he does not usually track collections. "But for this movie, I am keen on numbers. I want to tell people how this movie has performed, because they have stood by me. Rahman sir is asking me about the collection. I have to tell Anurag and Shekhar Kapur about it. I feel filmmakers are seeing their battle in the battle of this movie," notes Imtiaz, adding that the entire industry is rallying behind him. "For directors every boardroom discussion revolves around selling the movie. There are people constantly throwing diktats at you. They tell you how much your movie has to achieve on the opening day. This forces you to make a certain kind of film. So, when a movie like *Main Vaapas Aaunga*, the kind of film many wish to make, succeeds at the box office, they want to support it to the fullest." As the afternoon show ends at a multiplex in Bengaluru, Imtiaz greets his audience. Several talk about ancestors from Lahore. Some of them tear up, saying the Partition is a haunting memory for the nation. Some question his love for heart-breaking love stories and the idea of lovers recollecting their past as they yearn to reunite. "Inevitably, every memory has a tinge of sadness. Because memory is based on the past, and change is a process of loss. The loss of age, friends, time, or the loss of who you were," says Imtiaz, adding, "There is always a sense of poignancy in memory."



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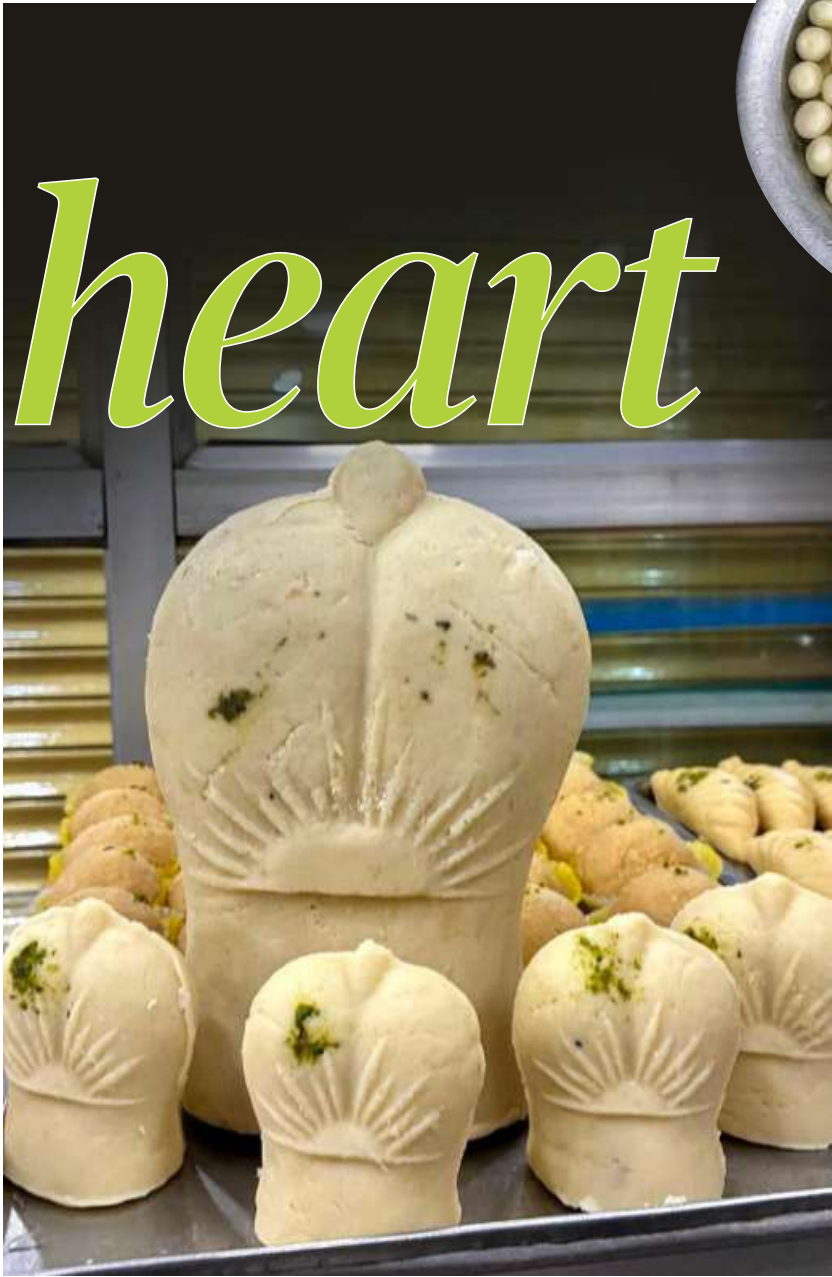
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Bengal's sweet heart

A burst of syrup, Rabindranath Tagore's approval, and a confectioner's imagination. This is the story of Chandannagar's newly GI-tagged jalbhara



burst forth, spilling down his *panjabi* (traditional kurta worn by men). The women of the household erupted in peals of laughter.

This marked the beginning of a new chapter for the Modak family. The fame of the jalbhara spread far and wide.

The Tagore connection

Today, that inheritance is carried forward by the family of fifth-generation owner, Saibal Kumar Modak. His wife Madhuri Modak and their two daughters Bhagyasree Modak and Gitasree Modak, the sixth generation, help preserve recipes and the 220-year-old legacy of Surjya Modak.

Gitasree tells us that Rabindranath Tagore, frequently stayed at Chandannagar's historic Patal Bari overlooking the Hooghly. During one such visit the poet sampled several sweets from the

Modak household.

Jalbhora delighted him, but another preparation especially caught his attention. Its delicate grains of *chhena* reminded him of tiny pearls or *moti*.

He christened it motichur sandesh, a name that survives to this day and has no connection to the motichoor laddoo.

Explaining the mystery of the sandesh, Gitasree explains, "The outer shell has such a consistency that it never absorbs the liquid inside. Even during summer, it can remain intact for four or five days without refrigeration."

Winter brings a version of jalbhara made entirely with fragrant *nolen gur* or date palm jaggery.

While the original jalbhara is priced at ₹65, the mango jalbhara is ₹90.

The milk, sugar, and *chhena* are procured from trusted suppliers in the surrounding suburbs.

Every week, consignments leave for Bengaluru, Hyderabad, Delhi and Mumbai, reaching customers within a day. Demand is also high across the United States.

"For international business, we needed official recognition. Earlier, everyone knew it as Surjya Modak's jalbhara. Now it has become Chandannagar's jalbhara. It places Chandannagar on the global map, and that makes us very happy," Gitasree smiles.

(Clockwise from right) Surjya Kumar Modak in Chandannagar, West Bengal; jalbharas on display; freshly made rossogollas at the shop; and other sweets that line the racks of Surjya Kumar Modak. SHREYA BANERJEE



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History has many hiding places. In West Bengal's Chandannagar, it settled inside sandesh. This old French river town entrusted its memory to a sweet no larger than the palm of a hand. It looks ordinary but beneath its unassuming exterior lies a trick worthy of a magician: a pocket of fragrant syrup that somehow refuses to escape.

On June 26, 2026, the jalbhara was awarded the Geographical Indication (GI) tag. The sweet, made by Surjya Modak and his son Siddheshwar Modak, has officially been acknowledged as a confection inseparable from the town where they imagined it nearly 220 years ago.

It has outlived empires, survived the departure of the French, the fading of the zamindars, shortages of sugar, changing tastes, refrigeration, express couriers and global migration.



But for nearly two centuries, jalbhara has left every first time visitor wondering the same thing: How can a sweet hold liquid without letting it escape?

To unravel this mystery, we drive 45 kilometres from Kolkata to Surjya Kumar Modak in Chandannagar, the birthplace of the jalbhara. Off-shoots of its popularity and fame, Chandannagar teems with several other Surjya Modaks.

The main shop is located at 247, Grand Trunk Road East, Barasat

Chandannagar, in the Hooghly district of West Bengal.

Alongside the new shop is the old shop where Surjya along with his son Siddheshwar created the sweet circa 1843-1844. Their only legitimate branch in Kolkata is in New Town Eco Park's Misti Hub at Gate Number 3.

Origin story

In the year 1250 of the Bengali calendar (around 1843-44), in the Telinipara neighbourhood of

Chandernagore, Surjya received a call from the wife or 'grihini' from the Telinipara zamindar's home.

Her request? To create a sweet unlike anything anyone had seen or tasted before for the newlywed groom and to playfully surprise him when he took his first bite.

To fulfill the zamindar's wife's request, Surjya and his son Siddheshwar deftly applied their craft. They created a mould that resembled the 'talshansh' or the translucent pulp of the ice apple.

In the mould, they added *chhena* (cottage cheese made by curdling cow milk). At the heart of the *chhena* they mixed aromatic rose extract with jaggery reduced to a sticky consistency (called *dolo*). They named this new creation "jalbhara" (water-filled) and sent it to the Telinipara household.

When the unsuspecting groom bit into the sweet, the hidden syrup

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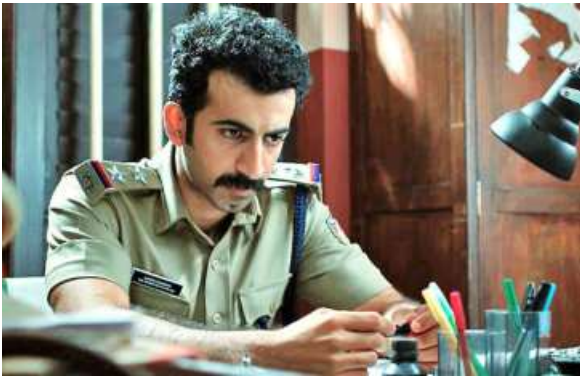
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Malayalam

Run-of-the-mill police procedural



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Padmakumar’s *Uyir*, is based on a real-life story and is also co-written by Shaji Maarad, a police officer, along with Nikhil M. Menon. Perhaps there is something about the variety of uncommon situations that the police force deals with on a daily basis that makes more officers turn to screenwriting.

The makers of *Uyir* have the advantage of working with a remarkable real story, with the possibilities of playing around with a plethora of human emotions. Unfortunately, it has not translated well on screen. After the body of an unidentified woman surfaces in an abandoned well, Ajeeb Rahman (Roshan Mathew), who is on probation as a sub-inspector, keeps tailing the leads across the multiple States. What on first impression seemed like a case of suicide soon turns out to be something far more serious with various strands.

M. Padmakumar, who has a commendable body of work including *Vasthavam* and *Joseph*, takes an unhurried approach to the crime, beginning with the personal trauma of the officer, which has now become a staple of most police procedurals. But in *Uyir*, the trauma part returns to the narrative only towards the end when a faint connection is drawn between the cause of the trauma and the case that Ajeeb is investigating.

The treatment of the film is such that at no point in the story does any of the revelations hit you hard, even when some of them are shocking enough. The writing has to take some of the blame for this. The same problem was visible in *Paathirathri* (2025), another police procedural scripted by Shaji Maarad. One of the strangest choices is the depiction of the different versions of a story by an unreliable narrator. When the story remains almost the same in the second narration with just an interchanging of characters, a quick montage would have conveyed the point, but the makers choose to go for a laboured re-enactment of the entire sequence at the same pace.

The screenplay is so structured that neither the shock of the crime or the emotions of the human story gets adequately conveyed. The dated approach that mars *Uyir* is also evident in the use of songs at the most inopportune moments in a film which really does not need any. The uninspiring background score further adds to this dated feeling. Roshan Mathew manages to convey the eagerness and vulnerability of a rookie police officer, but there is only so much that any of the actors can do in a film that does not provide them enough material to work with.

With its unimaginative and dated approach, *Uyir* does not break any ground and ends up as a run-of-the-mill police procedural.

Uyir is currently running in theatres



A script lost in the woods

Director Ahmed Khan misses the forest for the trees in this meta-comedy that demands absolute intellectual surrender

Hindi
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Welcome To The Jungle is yet another invitation to a cinematic universe that assumes a bigger budget and a massive star cast equal bigger laughs, as director Ahmed Khan treats the third installment of the popular franchise like a 164-minute variety show rather than a cohesive experience.

Based on late Neeraj Vora’s meta-story, it begins as a clever, self-aware critique of the film industry, where a corrupt corporate figure (Zakir Hussain), pushed by the changing political climate, decides to fund a guaranteed box-office flop to launder money. However, instead of exploiting the inherent situational irony of this film-within-a-film scam, writer Farhad Samji buries the narrative urgency under his characteristic, low-effort rhyming dialogues and disjointed sketch comedy and leaves it to Akshay Kumar and Johnny Lever to keep it afloat through their sheer improvisational brilliance.

Lever plays the pointsman of the business magnate who loses his voice in anxiety. He hires two floundering directors (Paresh Rawal and Rajpal Yadav) to cook up a story with a fading star, Rajeev (Akshay Kumar), and cast his erstwhile love interest (Disha Patani) as the heroine, and the producer’s daughter (Jacqueline Fernandez) for the oomph factor. The makers don’t want to completely sever the umbilical cord to the original. So, Suniel Shetty and Arshad Warsi step into the shoes of Nana Patekar and Anil Kapoor as the rogue elements

Welcome To The Jungle

Director: Ahmed Khan

Cast: Akshay Kumar, Raveena Tandon, Suniel Shetty, Johnny Lever, Jackie Shroff, Arshad Warsi, Paresh Rawal, Rajpal Yadav, Disha Patani, Jacqueline Fernandez

Synopsis: A group of misfits is unwittingly trapped in a fake, high-budget film produced by a corrupt businessman to launder massive black money.



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who want to play heroes in the film. When the inside-Bollywood jokes saturate, Khan shifts the base of the shoot to a village in Pakistan-Occupied Kashmir, ingeniously called Azad Nagar, where a terrorist (Jackie Shroff) is behaving like Gabbar Singh. In a pun on the guerrilla-style shooting, it leads to a meta showdown between the filmy *Khiladi* and *Zatara*.

The blatant use of the green-screen aesthetic strips the jungle of texture and danger. The action set pieces feel unwritten. They read as if the writer has prescribed, *insert 10 minutes of generic chaos here and five minutes there*. After a point, the scale becomes an exhausting distraction.

Having said that, we know Vora’s stories never relied on random silliness. They worked because desperate, deeply flawed characters were trapped in logically constructed, escalating nightmares. Here again, the meta-parody element shows a lot of promise. There are passages that force you to surrender the critical guard and anticipate what nonsense the talented ensemble will conjure up next. Amidst the cacophony, the film makes a couple of pertinent points. The tragi-comedic dynamic between Farida Jalal and Kiran Kumar serves as the film’s layered subtext. It functions as a sharp, satirical commentary on how the larger, modern society fundamentally mishears, misunderstands, and mocks Muslims. By having Jalal speak untranslatable gibberish that only Kumar can decode into chaste, superficially elegant Urdu, Khan crafts an allegory disguised as a laugh-out-loud gag.

The film finds its true comedic heartbeat and mass appeal when Khan plays on the image of actors to evoke humour, transforming the massive

ensemble from a casting burden into a self-referential playground. Casting Jacqueline as a blonde bimbo leans heavily on her real-life screen image of a glossy, high-glamour aesthetic and on Bollywood’s obsession with Western tropes. Similarly, pop icon Daler Mehndi turns his real-life persona into a joke. Nobody is spared. In a pun on the actor’s prolific box office choices, Akshay plays a fading star desperately seeking a second innings. The film crackles with anticipation as Raveena Tandon walks into the frame with Akshay, rekindling the embers that have been simmering since the 1990s.

However, when Khan pushes his ensemble into absolute overkill and unchecked overacting, the delicate balance of slapstick comedy gives way. Instead of eliciting organic laughter, the film begins to demand it aggressively. When a film boasts that many recognisable faces, the scenes start looking like a crowded waiting room where you can visually sense the actors standing inside the frame, at times disconnected from the scene, just waiting for their cue to deliver a single, isolated line. Krushna Abhishek and Yashpal Sharma are reduced to background decorations, desperately trying to slip in a single line.

The moments are engineered as a collection of 30-second conceptual hooks designed to trend on social media. Though CBFC scissors have a role to play as well, it seems the makers are more interested in creating viral Instagram reels to generate buzz than in building a substantial story. As a result, the trailer is excellent, but the theatrical experience crumbles, leaving the actors visibly stranded on screen.

Welcome to the Jungle is currently running in theatres.

Arjun Das, Anna Ben’s con game gives away its own trick

Tamil
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Plenty of examples from the world of cinema prove that there’s something truly primal about the satisfaction of witnessing a confidence trickster at work and rooting for them to get away with their spoils. Dulquer Salmaan rode that high to much acclaim a couple of years ago, and very few films have surpassed the recall value of Steven Spielberg’s *Catch Me If You Can*. There’s tremendous scope for storytelling left in the whole ‘desperate victim of situation turns towards trickery’ trope, so much so that even the prospect of watching *Con City*, starring Arjun Das and Anna Ben, felt exciting.

And much of the setting of this Harish Durairaj-directed Tamil film brims with the potential to become a fun entertainer about an unlikely gang of con artists, until the writing



begins to teeter away from that promise. *Con City* is the latest addition to the long list of Tamil mid-budget flicks that rely too heavily on an interesting one-liner to squander away character depth and ingenuity.

The fault in the mechanics of the film becomes all the more apparent by the end of the first half – the film begins to feel like a try-hard endeavour that obsessively revels in the peculiarity of its own ideas, though the pay-off isn’t all there. The

high-speed mocobot shots, slow-motion walks, parallel cuts, and grand reveals should have all worked, if not for the contrivance and superficial writing. Saravanan (Arjun at his best), Mithra (Anna), her differently abled son Jeeva (Agilan), Jackie (Yogi Babu), and Jackie’s mother Janaki (Vadivukkarasi) live as a family that runs a hotel in Mulki, Karnataka – except they are not really a family, but a group of convicts on the run from Chennai. We learn that

Saravanan’s fraud at the EB office where he worked, Mithra’s gamble with her fake rental management company, and Jackie and Janaki’s endeavour to use a trust as a front for circulating money all went kaboom.

Much of the first half follows these individual scams and the rollercoaster of emotions the leads went through. Each of them had suffered from a lack of means to lead a proper life, which pushed them into this life of crime. The inability to pay his home loan – and the pressure from the parents of his upper-middle-class girlfriend – pushes Saravanan over the edge. For Mithra, it is the inability to rent a house in the city. However, writer-director Harish struggles to portray the leads as both victims of their perilous situations and street-smart individuals who already seem to have the knack and know-how of con artistry. With Saravanan, at least, we see the jitters of embracing the other side, but we can’t say the same for others.

Setting off the conflict in the story is an ex-cop named Kalyana

Sundaram, who kidnaps Jeeva from his school. Now, before that, how did the family manage it all for seven long years in Mulki? Strangely, the interpersonal dynamics in this found family have hardly changed, except with the child, in these seven years. Post intermission, the film turns quite messy when this gang of convicts is forced to scheme one final scam – yours truly facepalmed the innumerable times when Saravanan’s bafflingly handy mimicry skills come to save the day (convenience apart, it takes

Con City

Director: Harish Durairaj

Cast: Arjun Das, Anna Ben, Yogi Babu, Vadivukkarasi

Storyline: When an ex-cop kidnaps the son of their found family, a group of convicts on the run must execute one last elaborate scam

conviction to cast this idea on an actor known for his base-heavy baritone voice). There’s nothing truly ‘brilliant’ about these mini-scams that make up the bigger scam, and the film doesn’t have the wit to turn it all into a comedy on amateur con artists who somehow manage to push through.

After a point, when the convenient turns pile up one after the other, and the whole act is repeatedly elevated with slow-motion amp-ups, you can’t help but feel indifference towards the characters. The dry humour saves the film in many places, but the writing keeps making us want to be saved from it. Of course, some ideas worked well in the film’s favour – like not revealing too much about whatever happened between Mithra and Jeeva’s biological father.

But overall, *Con City* only feels like watching a worn-out magician energetically perform a long-debunked magic trick.

Con City is currently running in theatres

Teach You A Lesson

Director: Hong Jong Chan

Cast: Kim Mu-yeol, Lee Sung-min, Jin Ki-joo, Pyo Ji-hoon

Synopsis: An Educational Rights Protection Bureau, led by an eclectic team, takes on issues plaguing the school education system



Revenge and reform

Korean

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In Teach You A Lesson, Netflix's new smash-hit drama, a quote by Albert Camus, "Nothing is more despicable than respect based on fear," is shown inscribed on the walls of a school. The camera only fleetingly dwells on this conscious, and cheeky placement of a quote. As early on in the series, we see school bullies being thrashed by the dozen.

Adapted from the webtoon, Get Schooled, Teach You A Lesson chronicles the adventures of the fictional Educational Rights Protection

Bureau (ERPB), an organisation authorised by the government to tackle the concerns that plague the school education system.

Led by Na Hwa-jin (Kim Mu-yeol), a former special forces officer-turned-school inspector, the ERPB, which also has the endearing and geeky Geun-dae (Pyo Ji-hoon) and the brash Im Han-rim (Jin Ki-joo) does not stop at anything; their methods are unconventional, and often, very violent. They are given a free reign by the education minister Choi Gang-Seok (Lee Sung-min), whose daughter was once engaged to Hwa-jin. Her tragic death binds the men in grief, and leads them on a quest for reform.

In the initial episodes, Teach You A Lesson trails its focus on school bullies who have made it increasingly hard for students to benefit from a flawed education system already grappling with commercialisation, competition and parental pressure. The format is that of an engaging procedural with each episode set in a different

school and the ERPB dealing with a range of different issues.

If the more run-of-the-mill episodes focus on students and delinquents who are reprehensible bullies on campus, we also have a kindergarten teacher harassed by overbearing parents, who drug their high school wards to ensure they beat the competition hollow. There's also an over zealous influencer whose false allegations against her teacher costs him his life.

Not every issue is afforded the nuance it deserves, and yet, the greatest triumph of To Teach You A Lesson lies in making viewers believe in its proposed, fantasy solutions for a system that is overburdened and broken. Are the methods horrifying? Largely, yes. The show has courted controversy in South Korea as well for its depiction of corporal punishment on campus.

Despite how grim the subject matter is, the show's writing keeps the proceedings consistently engaging, ensuring that the ERPB is

endearing and earnest. This is a career-best performance by Mu-yeol, who embodies Hwa-jin's cockiness, swagger and grief with ease. He is in able company of Lee Sung-min. The senior actor and Mu-yeol share a bromance born out of tragedy, and make for the best relationship in a show that is largely bereft of any big romance.

At just eight episodes, this Netflix original, much like the engaging 2025 medical dramedy, Trauma Code: Heroes On Call, makes a compelling case for shorter seasons and tighter writing, elevated by a string of superlative performances. Do we have a winning formula on our hands? Or a possible second season that sees the return of the ERPB? Either way, this is the no-frills entertainment that has been missing from K-Dramas for a while now. Get Kim Mu-yeol those awards already.

Teach You A Lesson is currently streaming on Netflix

Snippets



Ajay Devgn to star in the actioner Chauhaan; first look out

Ajay Devgn will be seen next in the actioner, Chauhaan, the makers announced on June 25 by unveiling the first look from the film. It will be released in theatres on October 1, 2027.

The teaser opens with a voice over of Ajay as visuals show an instance of stone pelting in Kashmir. Ajay's voiceover explains how the use of tear gas, water canon and pellet guns proved ineffective against the stone pelters.

The makers unveiled the first look on the occasion of Ajay's father, stunt director Veeru Devgan's birth anniversary.

More details about the plot and other actors from the film are awaited.



Absolute Batman animated series announced as DC expands slate

Warner Bros Animation and DC Studios have officially announced an animated adaptation of Absolute Batman, bringing one of DC's biggest comic book successes to the screen.

The project was unveiled during a joint presentation by Warner Bros Animation and DC Studios at the 2026 Annecy International Animation Film Festival. Based on the hit comic by Scott Snyder and Nick Dragotta, Absolute Batman sees Bruce Wayne lose only one parent and grow up in Gotham's working-class neighborhoods instead of the city's wealthiest circles. The result is a physically imposing, more aggressive Dark Knight.



Tenzing: Apple TV announces film recounting the conquest of Everest

Apple TV has announced an upcoming original feature film, Tenzing, which will be released on the platform on October 16 followed by its theatrical release on October 9. Directed by Jennifer Peedom, the film stars Genden Phuntsok, Tom Hiddleston, Willem Dafoe and Caitriona Balfe in pivotal roles.

The film tells the story of Himalayan climber Tenzing Norgay, who along with mountaineer Edmund Hillary were the first ones to summit Mount Everest. After being encouraged by his wife, Dawa (Thinley Lhamo), Tenzing finds an ally in his expedition secretary Jill Henderson (Caitriona Balfe).



Milly Alcock deserves better

Craig Gillespie's adaptation of Woman of Tomorrow strips Supergirl of everything that made her worth adapting, exposing a rebooted DC Universe repeating mistakes

English

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Last year, James Gunn's Superman tried to rebrand the most straight-laced, goody-two-shoes superhero in pop culture as "punk rock". Now, Craig Gillespie's adaptation of Tom King and Bilquis Evely's celebrated 2021 comic Supergirl: Woman of Tomorrow introduces the one major DC character who actually possesses a recognisably punk sensibility, only to sand away almost every abrasive edge that made her compelling on the page.

This is the second theatrical entry in the rebooted DC Universe overseen by James Gunn and Peter Safran, following Gunn's take on the Man of Steel. Instead of committing to Kal-El's Kryptonian super-cousin Kara Zor-El as the traumatised cosmic drifter whose anger exists in permanent dialogue with impossible ideals of heroism, Supergirl reduces its eponymous hero's first feature-film outing to the same faux-anarchic house style sludge that has metastasised across every superhero film touched by Gunn since Guardians of the Galaxy.

The film follows Kara, played by Milly Alcock, who survived the destruction of Krypton with memories fully intact, unlike her infant cousin Kal, who reached Earth too young to remember anything beyond the mythology later constructed around his origins. She celebrates turning 23 by hauling her super-dog Krypto across an interstellar pub crawl on planets orbiting red suns, exploiting the one astronomical loophole that temporarily deprives Kryptonians of their powers and allows her to drink herself into a rare state where survivor's guilt shuts up for a few hours.

The premise immediately distinguishes her from Superman, whose unbridled optimism stems from his ordinary upbringing in Kansas. Kara instead carries lived memories of cultural extinction that continue to haunt her. Ana Nogueira's

Supergirl

Director: Craig Gillespie

Cast: Milly Alcock, Matthias Schoenaerts, Eve Ridley, David Krumholtz, Emily Beecham, David Corenswet, Jason Momoa

Storyline: When an unexpected and ruthless adversary strikes too close to home, Supergirl reluctantly joins forces with an unlikely companion for an interstellar journey of vengeance and justice

writing gestures towards that interiority through a flashback sequence set in the last remnants of Krypton in Argo City, yet every revelation is just further spoon-fed exposition.

The screenplay's inability to organise Kara's inner life inevitably weakens every (non-canine) relationship orbiting her. The film pairs her with Ruthye, an adolescent girl played by Eve Ridley whose parents and brother are butchered by the space pirate Krem of the Yellow Hills, before she embarks on a galaxy-spanning revenge mission. Kara initially refuses to involve herself until Krem shoots Krypto with a poisoned dart whose only known antidote remains in his possession, turning the story into a race against the clock to save a very good dog.

In the original comic, Ruthye served as our point of entry into the story, recounting Kara's actions years later as though she had travelled alongside an almost mythic frontier hero whose unwavering belief in mercy survived repeated confrontations with unimaginable cruelty. This adaptation shifts the narrative almost entirely into Kara's perspective without constructing an equally compelling interior framework to replace it, leaving Ruthye stranded as another broadly sketched teenage sidekick whose personality rarely extends beyond solemn declarations of vengeance. Krem fares even worse because Matthias Schoenaerts receives almost nothing beyond an impressive collection of facial piercings, while the remainder of the NPC ensemble feels stiff and stranded across visual effects that never materialise into convincing environments.

Alcock largely escapes the wreckage because she seems to intuitively understand Kara beyond whatever the writing fails to articulate. Every exhausted shrug or sarcastic deflection, and every fleeting moment where Kara's guilt punctures her cultivated indifference suggests that the Australian actor constructed the emotional continuity independently of the material surrounding her. Almost everybody else is pure collateral damage.

The production's drab visual identity

proves just as dispiriting. Gillespie previously translated the damaged interiority of protagonists like Tonya Harding in I, Tonya and Estella in Cruella into a distinctive cinematic language through an irreverent visual confidence that reflected their unstable psychology. Almost none of that survives here. Supergirl is suffocated with dull, digitised textures across anonymous LED volume horizons and interchangeable alien settlements that appear assembled from recycled concept art discarded after Guardians of the Galaxy. Krem's army of Brigands too, fare no better as antagonists because they amount to little beyond recycled Ravagers.

Gunn did not direct Supergirl, though his creative DNA has become so deeply institutionalised within the rebooted DC Universe that his fingerprints remain visible across almost every other major creative decision as well. Each aggressively curated needle-drop and every wisecracking grotesque recalls sensibilities that once felt idiosyncratic in his work at Marvel before endless repetition has since transformed them into egregious templates.

The film's political imagination is almost as impoverished as its visual one. Every supposed act of feminist conviction or self-determination feels sterile and focus-tested. Replace Kara with almost any interchangeable female supe, and remarkably little about its performative empowerment would change. It possesses no discernible worldview beyond the exhausting blockbuster ritual of congratulating itself for discovering that women can also anchor billion-dollar consumer products.

I disliked Gunn's Superman despite appreciating Corenswet's fundamentally decent interpretation of Clark Kent, and Supergirl only deepens my skepticism toward this incarnation of the DC Universe. It embodies exactly the kind of aesthetic monoculture Martin Scorsese warned was swallowing mainstream cinema and is simply the latest casualty of that cultural regression.

Supergirl is currently running in theatres